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Does public relations scholarship need better PR? practitioners' perspectives on academic research

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ABSTRACT

Articles in academic public relations journals often provide recommendations for public relations practitioners. The purpose of this study is to gain a practitioner perspective on that work and to determine if a potential disconnect between public relations practitioners and scholars exists. Through semi-structured, in-depth interviews with 22 public relations practitioners, this study examines knowledge, readership, and applicability of public relations scholarship in industry. Participants indicated they have a general awareness of and assigned value to academic scholarship; however, they do not actively consider it or use it in their professional lives due to issues of access, time, and relevance. Many appeals have been made within the academy to make scholars' work more "public," and these results reflect this need. Based on these findings, recommendations are made to increase the accessibility and relevance of scholarly work for professionals.

1. Introduction

At the close of many academic public relations publications is a sentence, a paragraph, or sometimes an entire section devoted to addressing what public relations practitioners should consider following the results of the study in question. The calls of some public relations journals and academic association divisions specifically reference practitioners as either being an audience for, or a participant in, the published scholarship. While much lip service is given to producing analyses and content that will be valuable to industry practice, how much of it actually is? This work, through semi-structured, in-depth interviews with active public relations professionals ($N = 22$), examines the readership, applicability, and challenges to access of public relations scholarship among practitioners in order to begin to understand the current connections between academic research and use of that research in practice. We find challenges for practitioners related to available time to locate and process scholarship, and accessibility and relevance of that scholarship. This evidences a continued and potentially problematic scholar/practitioner divide, which could eventually reduce competence and capacity of the field, as one of the main impediments to developing professional capability among practitioners identified by Tsetsura and Vergara (2021) was inability to engage in continuous education. The divide may have been reflected in the disastrous crisis communication and public health response to the COVID-19 pandemic, which exhibited

little evidence of research-based best practices (Roumen, Jelen, & L'Etang, 2022). Our findings guide a set of recommendations toward improving connections between research and practice.

2. Review of literature

2.1. State of the field

While varying perspectives exist, public relations practice and scholarship are broadly focused on the "flow of purposive communication produced on behalf of individuals, formally constituted and informally constituted groups, through their continuous transactions with other social entities," as Edwards (2012, p.21) defines it in her effort to resolve the various, and sometimes conflicting, paradigms that surround public relations. The public relations industry and the scholarship of public relations have experienced significant growth over the past 30 years (Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2017). The growing value organizations place on strong reputations and engagement among publics has led to increased demand for public relations services, which has contributed to the (still) flourishing popularity of public relations as a program of study at U.S. universities (Botan & Taylor, 2004). Since Botan and Taylor's (2004) State of the Field, scholarly output and focus has grown considerably, reflective of an increase in Ph.D.'s awarded and an increased focus on theory and scholarship in faculty hires, rather than

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only technical skills (Commission on Public Relations Education, 1999). With this new focus, the rate of publication of academic articles focusing on public relations has grown significantly since 2004, with 949 publications indexed in the database Communication Source Complete (with author supplied keyword “public relations”) in the 14 years of 2004–2019, compared only to 45 in the 14 years prior to 2004. Public relations has a clear and eponymous connection to its professional field, and many articles in public relations-focused or publishing journals note a desire, or an intention, to serve that professional field by sharing findings and recommendations with practitioners. However this view is not absolute, as Cheng and De Gregorio (2008) point out, academic and industry public relations are sometimes treated as “distinct entities” varying significantly in their philosophical orientation toward public relations, with some scholars arguing that academic research should maintain a healthy distance from industry, decoupled from the focus on the organization, from industry in order to facilitate critique and allow for a better discussion of the social and cultural implications of the practice of public relations (Holbrook, 1995; Edwards, 2012).

2.2. “Practitioners should note...”

While not the goal or focus of all work, and nor should it be, articles in academic public relations journals often provide recommendations for take-aways for public relations practitioners. This suggested discourse or pursuit of change may come in different forms, but it most frequently addresses practitioners or professionals and provides recommendations for consideration outside of public relations scholarship. *Public Relations Review* (PRR) and *Journal of Public Relations Research* (JPRR) published the highest volume of research in the years 2007–2017, and represented, along with *Public Relations Inquiry* and *Journal of Communication Management*, the top academic journals in PR (Jelen-Sanchez, 2017). To better understand and document the intent of the journals focused specifically on public relations and to guide this study, we conducted an exploratory examination of PRR and JPRR utilizing the journals’ search functions.

Considering the 2016–2018 issues, PRR published at least 84 articles that unambiguously sought to inform practitioners in their discussion and implications sections how or what to consider when applying the study at hand with their profession. The topics of these articles span many aspects of the industry including social media, crisis communication, and more. As examples, Roberts and Veil (2016) state, “Practitioners should consider the added value of supporting images for instructional messages and the role of those images in improving the comprehension of information for individuals with basic or below basic literacy skills who obtain most of their health information from television media” (p. 217). Len-Rios, Hughes, McKee, and Young (2016) focused on the audience of practitioners and address the public of early adolescents using social media, parental mediation, and Internet literacy, ultimately claiming, “Practitioners, who often pride themselves as serving as an organization’s ethical conscience, should also consider the ethics involved with using these channels for engaging with early adolescent audiences” (p. 107). While these are only a couple of examples, it is evident that many articles published in PRR are written with practitioners and practical take-aways in mind.

Similarly, though with slight variation, JPRR frequently provides direction for public relations practitioners. However, many of the articles in JPRR provide recommendations on how practitioners could or should implement results of the research, rather than what practitioners should consider in their thinking. For example, Rim and Kim (2016, p. 264) provide a recommendation, “... practitioners could utilize the proposed measurement for managing public skepticism in the context of CSR to better source reputational benefits of CSR.” Considering 2016–2018, of 49 articles published, half (24) specifically address practitioners.

Though only an exploratory analysis, clearly many scholars seek to inform practice with their research. In addition, the valuable work being

done by the Institute of Public Relations (IPR), the Arthur W. Page Society, and the Public Relations Society of America (PRSA) Educator’s Academy actively seeks to connect researchers and practitioners by developing content and opportunities for both. Ideally, scholarship should contribute to a mutually beneficial relationship where practitioners value, seek out, and consider results and adopt some recommendations made in scholarship, developing, and testing, research-based strategies which validate research and contribute to the growth of the field and thus demand for trained PR graduates. However, it is not clear whether that relationship actually exists, with indications that it is at best weak and at worst entirely disconnected (Cheng & de Gregorio, 2008; Claeys & Opgenhaffen, 2016).

2.3. Scholar-practitioner disconnect

Concerns over a potential disconnect between practitioners and scholars within PR are not new - entire conferences and conference themes have been developed to specifically address such concerns, which first began to emerge in the 1970s (Cheng & de Gregorio, 2008). While recent data specifically establishing or examining the supposed disconnect are thin, Gower (2006) and Broom (2006) identify and discuss it, and Cheng and de Gregorio (2008) empirically document it among scholars; and all argue that researchers should ensure their work was of use to practitioners, implying that some work has become too theory-focused to be useful beyond academia. Furthermore, the work of scholars does not seem to be reaching practitioners through the trade press targeted at them, as Merle and Callison (2012) found less than 1 % of articles in *PR News* and other PR-adjacent trade journals citing academic research. Concerns about this issue were revived by the COVID-19 pandemic, with Roumen et al. (2022) arguing that pervasive communication gaps persisted between academic experts and communication and health authorities on the ground, with fault for the problem to be found on both sides.

Practitioners have long perceived public relations research to be casual and informal instead of scientific, believing most relevant research was done was by practitioners rather than trained researchers, with little need for an underlying body of theoretical knowledge (Cheng & de Gregorio, 2008). There have been few indications of awareness and adoption of scholarly work among practitioners (Macnamera, 1999), or consistency in perceptions on the industry between scholars and practitioners (Claeys & Opgenhaffen, 2016). Evaluating the possibility of a uniform standard of professionalism, Sallot, Cameron, and Weaver Lariscy (1997) found many differences in responses between educators and practitioners. Educators were less likely to foresee a standard for continued education or certifications and trainings, and overall the two groups did not share opinions on many of the topics measured, giving some of the first indications of a scholar-practitioner disconnect (Sallot et al., 1997). Jugo, Ciboci, and Alvanja (2017) demonstrated the need for cooperation between educational institutions and the labor market, an equal ratio of theory and practice, and involvement of practitioners in higher education, noting marked differences in expectations between practitioners and educators. This difference in expectations of practitioners and educators was also noted by Tsetsura and Vergara (2021), who found that each group sees different impediments to full actualization of the capabilities of the public relations profession. Much existing research focuses on educators and educational programs as preparing future practitioners (e.g., Jugo et al., 2017; Verwey, Benecke, & Muir, 2017; Waymer, Brown, Baker, & Fears, 2018) or on the scholar perspective on the divide (e.g., Gower, 2006; Cheng & de Gregorio, 2008); but research is limited on the perspective of current practitioners toward their continued learning or use of academic scholarship after completing their education.

The clearest evidence of a disconnect between scholarship and practice comes from one of the only studies to examine use of scholarship and theory in public relations practice: Claeys and Opgenhaffen (2016) examined the use of crisis communication theory by crisis

practitioners, with participants reporting a schism between scholars and practitioners due to the lack of ability to translate published work into practical use. Practitioners perceived theory as too abstract, and therefore, hard to convert into daily work, which confirms concerns identified in earlier work (see [Cheng & de Gregorio, 2008](#)). This information led to the conclusion that practitioners charged with crisis communication make decisions on experience and gut feelings instead of theories of best response ([Claeys & Opgenhaffen, 2016](#)), which is consistent with [Gregory and Watson's \(2008\)](#) finding little evidence that measurement models developed and recommended by academics were being deployed by practitioners, which may be due to practitioners valuing experience and intuition to be more important than academic research ([Lages & Simkin, 2003](#)). [Gregory and Watson \(2008\)](#) also noted academics seemed largely unaware of industry trends and developments, and were not attuned with industry information sources (such as *PR Week*), which rarely mention academic research.

Marketing and public relations professionals rank advances in research as fifth among important trends impacting the future of the industry ([Cartwright, 2017](#)) and issues of available time outrank skills and education concerns among professionals, though they do indicate that problems of available time (and employer support) is the *reason* continued education is not more important ([Tssetura & Vergara, 2021](#)), indicating demand for scholarship among professionals might be currently be weak but has potential for development if barriers can be identified and removed. With the rapid growth of scholarship within academic public relations and the stated intentions of important outlets and many authors, one is left wondering if it has the impact on the industry it purports to have, and how a potential disconnect manifests. This study seeks to investigate this disconnect, examining the role PR scholarship does and could play within professional development and education and what barriers exist to fulfilling that role. The ultimate aim here is better developing the academic and practitioner relationship through shared knowledge. Most prior work has examined the scholar side of this disconnect, but the in the present work, the practitioner side of that relationship is explored, to understand the knowledge of, access to, and application of PR scholarship by practitioners, in order to understand how to maximize the symbiotic relationship that could, and should, exist.

We first pose two guiding research questions:

RQ1: How do public relations practitioners perceive public relations scholarship as playing a role in their continuing education?

RQ2: How do public relations practitioners value academic public relations scholarship?

Second, given professional development and continued education is considered essential for public relations practitioners to succeed in the changing professional landscape ([Harvard Extension School, 2014](#)), even while practitioners struggle to find the time to engage ([Cheng & de Gregorio, 2008](#); [Tssetura & Vergara, 2021](#)), we seek to explore how practitioners are presently updating their knowledge, what barriers exist to doing so, and how public relations scholarship could fit into process, if at all.

RQ3: What are perceived challenges and limitations to practitioners integrating scholarship in their professional lives?

RQ4: How do practitioners prefer to update their skills and knowledge?

Finally, while we certainly do not mean to imply that scholarship should exist *only* to serve industry, we seek to explore how to best involve and develop capability and competence in the profession through increased awareness of and attention to academic work. [Cheng and de Gregorio \(2008\)](#) found in their mid-2000s survey of scholars that 50.5 % felt that the relationship between scholars and practitioners should be “somewhat close”, with another 35.2 % indicating they would prefer it “very close.” Only 3.3 % thought those relationships should be “somewhat” or “very distant.” However, barely 20 % of those respondents felt like the scholar-practitioner relationship was, in reality, even somewhat close, and many of those surveyed lamented that

practitioners were indifferent to their work. Thus, it is clear that many scholars want a better relationship and our final research question explores how to help them achieve that.

RQ5: What could the academy do better to support the work of practitioners?

3. Method

3.1. Semi-structured interviews

To answer these questions, a qualitative approach was employed, as it “frees the investigator from the burden of forcing a priori standards on an audience” ([McLeod, Bybee, & Durall, 1982](#), p. 3). A qualitative method is particularly valuable for this research because particular attitudes toward and applications of academic research in public relations would be difficult to construct a priori by those who conduct academic research. Semi-structured, in-depth interviews “serve the useful purpose of exploring many respondents more systematically and comprehensively as well as to keep the interview focused on the desired line of action” ([Jamshed, 2014](#), p. 87). This type of interview was specifically chosen for their ability to be personalized to the specific participant, their private nature given the potential for sensitive or embarrassing disclosures, and because varying and busy schedules of active practitioners would not have allowed for other qualitative methods, such as focus groups.

3.2. Participants

To identify potential participants, purposive sampling ([Lindlof & Taylor, 2011](#)) was employed. Lists of active public relations practitioners were compiled from the professional and organizational (i.e., PRSA) networks of the researchers and then, using LinkedIn, credentials and years of experience were recorded in order to develop a list of individuals with of varied years of experience, educational background, geographical location, and type of job (agency, corporate, institutional, or other). From the initial list of 93 individuals, email invitations were sent requesting a Skype, phone, or in-person interview to 40, selected to provide the broadest range of experience across the sample. From this, 22 interviews were conducted across two researchers (11 each), with non-response or scheduling issues accounting for the other 18 invitees. The researchers had no personal or professional relationship with any of the interviewees. All participants were three or more years removed from their undergraduate degree with an average of 9.78 years of professional experience. Years of experience ranged from three to 29 years; 13 participants categorized themselves as mid-level, six categorized themselves as senior-level, two as junior/assistant-level, and one (a self-employed consultant) did not categorize. The participants worked in agencies (12), corporate PR (5), higher education/institutional PR (4), or were consultants (1); and all were employed in the United States, yet were geographically diverse in their location of employment with 10 states represented (however, 12 participants worked in Missouri or Illinois, so the Midwest was over-represented). Fourteen participants were female (63 %). Eight participants earned master's degrees in communication, public relations, or marketing, one had a master's in history, and one was working toward a master's in strategic communication.

3.3. Procedure

Interviews were conducted mostly via Skype and were recorded for later transcription. The majority of interviews were between 30 and 40 minutes long. Guiding interview questions (Appendix 1) were developed by the researchers in advance and were pilot-tested on a sample interview candidate for feedback and clarity prior to executing the interview process. The qualitative nature of the interviews facilitated a response-driven format, allowing for significant follow-up conversations that

flowed organically around areas related to the research questions, and for occasional digressions (Rubin & Rubin, 2005).

3.4. Analysis

An inductive approach was taken to make sense of the data generated by the interviews, which were pseudonymized to protect participants' confidentiality. Recordings of the interviews were transcribed by research assistants, and the transcripts were analyzed by the researchers, coding for content addressing the study's research questions. Main themes and sub-themes were developed from these transcripts, and supporting evidence in the form of direct quotes cataloged.

4. Findings and discussion

In conducting the interviews, it became readily evident our participants rarely, if ever, used or were exposed to public relations scholarship. Participants indicated, overall, that they knew of academic scholarship. Many valued it in principle; but these practitioners do not actively consider it or use it in their professional lives for a variety of reasons, subsequently discussed. Given that many participants saw the potential value of well-conducted and unbiased research, some saw opportunities to develop increased, and simplified, access through the use of newsletters, blogs, and social media.

We first examined if practitioners perceive a role for academic research in their working lives and continuing education (RQ1) and received some stark answers. "None at all," replied participant Rachel (agricultural communication and marketing), "I don't pay attention... and I wouldn't know where to look," concurred Jennifer, a seasoned media relations industry veteran. Others noted awareness but lack of use: "(I don't use it)...as often I would have initially thought (after my masters). I can't remember the last time I read a study" (Emily, corporate communication). Three participants with master's degrees acknowledged much of they had learned in graduate school was based on academic scholarship, but beyond that acknowledgment, answers received across participants were almost totally consistent that practitioners do not perceive a role for it in their working lives.

When we inquired whether they valued academic scholarship or not (RQ2), results were more positive, but mixed. One participant noted that, "(it is) very important, but unfortunately, I just don't see a lot of this research in my regular outlets where I consume information and news. Another respondent, PR manager Judy, argued that, "[academic research] has value, but I think it has to be delivered in a way that is easy to comprehend and makes sense for an industry or brand." Richard, an agency vice president, lamented the time needed to keep up:

I guess really what we are talking about is...the time it takes versus the time you have. Even in my role...I have longer term projects that I am excited about and want to include market and academic research but just the routine of every day you can't really get into, and that was a surprise...I expected to use and keep up with it more based on my education, but I just can't.

It was clear that most, though not all, of those who were aware of it thought there was value to academic scholarship in general. When asked to go further with their answers, and exploring what the challenges and limitations are to practitioners integrating PR scholarship in their work (RQ3), three themes emerged: Access, time, and relevance. These issues helped begin to support the existence of, and determine some reasons for, a disconnect between the academic study and professional practice of PR.

4.1. Impediments to industry use of academic research

4.1.1. Access

Academic journals, often hidden behind paywalls, are less accessible once a person is removed from university campuses. Consequently,

individuals who *had* tried to access research they knew was relevant to their work, could not. Some assumed university databases were the only way to access articles, and awareness of any non-university options, for example Google Scholar or ResearchGate, never emerged. Participants also indicated they had trouble knowing what sources existed, and which were "good ones" within academia, so they could not go directly to the journal to see what was being published. Gunther, an agency professional, stated, "I wouldn't really know where to go...to make it work for a pitch, you need to know where the research is, be able to include it quickly, and know it is accurate." Monica, an institutional PR manager, indicated that, "It needs to be where the readers are. I don't see a lot of academic research. It doesn't mean it isn't out there, it just isn't in front of me (in the outlets I follow)." Monica also pointed out that academic sources do not show up in her Google searches for a particular topic (something replicated by these authors who were surprised at the observation), which could reflect either Google not indexing Google Scholar to the main search, or academic authors not using common/industry terms in abstracts or titles. Thus, it became clear that access to and visibility of scholarship and findings is partially at fault for the lack of use. Practitioners are not aware of, have trouble finding, or are not following outlets that feature scholarship, and scholars and the journals they publish in are not succeeding in getting their scholarship featured in industry outlets that practitioners *do* follow.

4.1.2. Time

Related to access, while many participants noted that they assume value to scholarship, they did not have the time to invest in locating, reading, and subsequently translating for practice a 25-page manuscript. In particular, those in agency PR noted the issue of time, pointing out that all of their daily time needed to be attributed to something for billing, and keeping up on scholarship was not likely to be something a client considered a worthy expenditure of time on their account. Kathy indicated, "Oh I have a free 30 min here and there, but that is not enough time to look at anything, especially a big article, in depth." Those in corporate communication also wished they had time during their workdays to keep up, with Ursula noting that, "It is one of those things you wish you had time to do. You wish you had time to study. I shouldn't say that, because if it was truly important to me I would stay up until midnight doing it, but at this point I am not." Discussion of the lack of time available for reading, even though some discussed their employer's support for professional development activities, led to a discussion of relevance among many participants.

4.1.3. Relevance

Discussion of the lack of time available for reading led to a discussion of relevance of academic work among many participants. Due to perceptions of irrelevance, few participants thought their employers would support exerting resources to find and read such involved work, even if it helped them develop their skills. Participants consistently reported that, when they did come across academic research, it was too complex to see the relevance in some of it, "a lot of academic research, regardless of the field, is hard to translate to real life. That's my view, and I think it is pretty consistent across the industry," Phoebe, a senior agency account executive, argued. In discussing relevance, at least a third of participants brought up the value of developing instincts as more relevant than being better read.

"A lot of people use their education as a crutch...but not everything is like the book or the like it was supposed to be in some study. People need to learn to make their own mistakes and just figure it out," Bobby, mid-career at an agency, stated, concurring with others. Other participants argued (consistent with the findings of [Claeys and Ogenhaffen, 2016](#)) the industry still valued experience and learning to trust your gut instincts, over training and education. While this was a common refrain, some noted that overreliance on instinct was not a good thing, and they would like to see more data-driven decision-making. Barry noted that, "I think a lot of what makes us a good PR person is our gut, but we want to

make sure it is grounded in something to help make our case. Research could really help with that.” However, he went on to point out that, “it just needs to be in more relevant industry outlets, in a way we can comprehend it.”

4.2. Sources of knowledge

While a limited number of participants were currently engaging with PR scholarship, many noted that they would if there was “a better way” to do so. When discussing the ways they maintain their industry knowledge (RQ4) practitioners noted the sources they *do* currently follow to improve their knowledge and skills are accessible, summarized, and free, low-cost or subscription-based (with subscriptions sometimes provided by their employer). Outlets specifically mentioned were: PR Daily, PR News, *Ad Week*, LinkedIn, PRSA’s *Tactics*, Spin Sucks and other industry blogs. Many noted the value of news summaries, like *Ad Age*’s Wake Up Call, and The Skim, which deliver snippets of news (with accompanying links for more information), as both time-conscious and relevant-point driven. Richard noted, “I need it in my inbox in the morning, summarized, and ready to go” and went on to say that if the accessibility, and, as he put it, “digestibility” of PR research could be increased, he would be very receptive to it. In the only mention of seeing academic research included in another outlet, Judy, a marketing and PR manager, noted that, “I (see) it on a few industry bloggers’ pages. They provide a high-level overview and summarize findings to speak to how you can relate the research to your work.” She went on to discuss how valuable these summaries were and noted that she specifically followed one of the blogs because the blogger so effectively accomplished this.

Outside of industry publications and blogs, some participants discussed using platforms like LinkedIn Learning, a subscription-based program of technology, business and creative courses, and training webinars hosted by Cision and PR News to update their skills and knowledge. None mentioned noticing academic research included in these services. Finally, Twitter as a source for industry news came up frequently, but that seemed to be based on their network’s sharing content from the aforementioned industry blogs and publications, not from content created by individual Twitter users. Two participants also mentioned that they got quite a bit of industry insight from the Twitter feeds of service providers such as Sprout Social and Cision.

4.3. Forging connections

Consistent with both [Claeys and Opgenhaffen \(2016\)](#) and [Cheng and De Gregorio \(2008\)](#), these results evidence a disconnect between PR practice and scholarship persists, even in the face of decades of discussion focused on ending it. In a field that prides and defines itself on the flow of purposive communication (Edwards, 2012), it is notable that connections between the work of practitioners and academics interested in the same processes are rare, at least in this sample. It is also lamentable as many of the programs and research centers devoted to PR at universities were started by practitioners seeking to better inform the field ([Cheng & de Gregorio, 2008](#)). If researchers seek to contribute knowledge to the professional practice of PR, building relationships with practitioners ([Cheng and de Gregorio, 2008](#)) and driving competence and capacity for the field ([Tsutsura & Vergara, 2021](#)), they need to get their findings in front of practitioners, in the sources they are already accessing and the seminars and conferences they are already attending. Many participants in this study, when asked what scholars could do support the work of practitioners (RQ5) and thus the development of relationships and the field overall, described a version of participant Richard’s argument to “do better PR for your work.” This could include facilitating the placement of findings in industry outlets (traditional, new, and social) or developing a presence for work in the social space through active social media outreach. Some also suggested working with industry groups like PRSA to ensure that faculty work is featured in newsletters like PRSA’s *Tactics* and on organizational websites. Beyond

access, a simplification of the work would be appreciated, as Monica (institutional PR) noted that information overload is a major problem in both her professional and personal life, and she frequently just does not have the bandwidth left to sift and process more. It was evident practitioners wanted access to relevant findings in a simplified format but needed the authors of those findings to get the information into their informational feeds, through media relations, outreach, and social media activity. While some would argue that many scholars and professional organizations are already trying to do much of this, it is clear from these findings that the efforts have yet to bear fruit.

4.4. Recommendations

Most of the conversations in academia about publicly-engaged scholarship have focused on conducting research that serves the greater public good, and then publicizing that research so it fulfills that goal. However, one should not forget that part of the “public” is the industries we are training our students for and the professionals they will work among. There is a ready audience for our work, but that work needs to be accessible and relevant to the needs of those professionals. Based on these interviews and a later conversation with industry professionals and editors around the results of this study at (blinded for review), we first make six specific recommendations both for individual authors and for the editorial boards of scholarly publications hosting this work. Then, because if this is truly to be a mutually beneficial relationship between scholars and practitioners, we also make recommendations for practitioners to better enable their engagement with scholarship.

First, scholars should work with their university’s media relations team to help identify and then target niche industry publications. Many media relations departments are chronically understaffed and are unfamiliar the diversity of industry outlets serving various content areas and majors. Second, many agencies maintain research departments, or hire external specialty firms, charged with creating, managing, and distributing relevant research for their clients. These individuals in some ways serve as gatekeepers to practitioners and could be a vector of summarized and shared findings. Third, while it may seem obvious, include the most relevant research findings clearly stated in abstracts, leaving statistics and jargon for the body of the manuscript, and provide bulleted “highlights” in journals, as *Public Relations Review* does. These are accessible before paywalls. Fourth, journal editorial boards should consider whether effective media relations and outreach can be supported at their journals, potentially engaging interns to help. Fifth, work to better support, integrate, and develop Continued Professional Development (CPD) programs, and practice-oriented PhDs and masters. These programs are more common in the United Kingdom, Australia, and New Zealand, but offer practitioners the opportunity to come back to university and immerse themselves in valuable research, but with the intention of taking that research back to their practice, not to a future career in academia. Finally, authors should consider becoming a public advocate for their own work and also the work of organizations such as IPR and the International Public Relations Research Conference that are already working to address some of these issues. This can be done through social media (specifically, a blog or an active industry-focused Twitter that regularly interacts with media professionals), responding to #HARO (Help A Reporter Out) requests and media inquiries quickly, and keeping your credentials current on “expert lists” maintained by universities. Journalists actively source stories through Twitter and other social platforms ([Brandtzaeg, Lüders, Spangenberg, Rath-Wiggins, & Følstad, 2016](#)), so there is evidence that an active and updated blog, written in accessible and industry-focused language and linked through from a similarly active and focused Twitter account, would help make connections that lead to coverage in the outlets practitioners read.

Practitioners, facing ever-increasing demands on their knowledge and skills, also need to make an effort to engage better in this content. Many of our participants noted a desire to engage, but little action.

Earlier work, corroborated by the participants here, implicated limited time available or budgeted into an employee's day as the reason skills building and continued education among professionals is not given higher priority. Some in the industry have become proponents of the concept of "reading time", a 30–60 minute window blocked off in an employee's calendar to focus on industry and academic work (see Strong, 2015), and that is something we recommend encouraging as an industry norm. To find what to read during this time, we encourage practitioners to make use of Google Scholar alerts for concepts of interest, implement RSS readers curated to include a mix of industry and scholarly sources, and follow scholars on social media, Twitter in particular, where many already share and discuss their work.

4.5. Limitations

This fact that this study was conducted by public relations scholars about public relations scholarship is a main limitation. Participants knew they were talking to people who conducted the type of research discussed. This may have been reflected in all the participant discussion of valuing it while still admitting they did not use it or seek it out. However, given that participants felt comfortable enough to discuss never using it, we believe the results are valid. Also, the sample was a purposive sample of U.S. practitioners, limited to participants in the broad professional networks of the researchers, with the midwestern U. S. overrepresented as nearly 50 % of the sample. While efforts were made to ensure diversity of experience and professional focus in the sample, it is likely not reflective of the entire and increasingly global public relations field.

5. Conclusions

The purpose of this study was to investigate issues regarding the utility of public relations scholarship to industry. Many appeals have been made in the academy to make scholars' work more "public," and our results reflect this continued need. The work of valuable organizations and institutions that are endeavoring to do this work (IPR, IPRRC, PRSA, The Page Society, etc.) should be engaged with and supported, but scholars should also seek to make connections with industry and industry press themselves, as it will benefit both parties. We, as scholars, need to focus on making our work matter beyond academia, not because academic research *has* to serve industry or the responsibility falls entirely on us, but to do so ensures the professionalism, integrity, and continued growth of the field, and may have distinct societal benefits, especially in the areas of public health and crisis communication (Roumen et al., 2022). To put it simply, we need to do better PR for the excellent work done in academic public relations to demonstrate our—and our work's—relevance to the field, and we hope to contribute to the conversation about how to do so.

Appendix 1

Interview Protocol.

(General welcoming conversation and request for consent to record).

Demographic Questions:

Please tell me your first name, age, country where you are from and where you are working (city) and also a little about:

- Education level.
- Gender.
- Type of job and a little about the org (type of org – corporate/institution/agency).
- Level within the organization and number of years worked in PR.

Interview Questions for PR Practitioners:

How were you trained/educated to work in the PR field? Through your major? Practical experiences? Trainee programs?

How do you continue to train to excel in your job or update your

knowledge? (alternative: How do you learn more about the field as you practice?).

(follow up, if not volunteered, ask what sources they follow).

What skills do you consider to be necessary in order to work effectively and efficiently in the PR field?

What does "Public Relations" mean to you? How would you define it?

We already talked a little bit about sources, but do you personally value going outside resources provided to you by your employer to develop your skills and knowledge? Do you have time to?

What sources do you use to stay current and informed on industry news?

Follow up if affirmative: Do you feel supported in your job in developing your skills and knowledge by employer?

How aware are you of academic studies in public relations and marketing? When I say academic research, I mean studies conducted by faculty at universities and published in academic journals and publications. Not aware is ok! We're interested in everything.

Follow up if negative: Thank them for their time, move along.

(If aware) Does academic research have a role in your learning?

Overall, what's your view of the value of academic research in PR?

Has your view of public relations academics and research changed since entering the industry?

What opportunities and/or challenges do you perceive to reading, accessing, or integrating academic PR research?

How often do you see professors and their research featured or research studies discussed in the sources you DO follow? (like PR Daily).

What gets in the way of your developing your skills and knowledge in PR? What challenges to you perceive?

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